Habit-Memory, Pure Recollection, and Lived Duration (Bergson 1896)

Bergson's dual memory architecture differentiates motor habit-memory from episodic pure memory, establishing that lived duration is qualitative and continuous rather than a spatialized sequence of clock ticks, directly illuminating the trade-offs of Bergson duration versus spatialized time in AI architectures.

GRADE: HIGH | STATUS: STABLE | DOMAIN: TECHNICAL, ORGANIZATIONAL, PHILOSOPHICAL | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

In Matière et mémoire (1896) and Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience (1889), Henri Bergson established that human memory and consciousness operate across two distinct structural poles: motor habit-memory (mémoire-habitude) and dated episodic pure memory (souvenir pur). Habit-memory is somatic, procedural, and automatic—such as reciting a memorized poem or riding a bicycle—where the schema survives while the historical occasion of its acquisition is discarded. Pure memory, by contrast, is contemplative, non-motor, and singular, recording unique dated events that can never recur identically. Furthermore, Bergson demonstrated that true duration (durée réelle) is qualitatively heterogeneous and interpenetrating, whereas standard scientific measurement superimposes spatial concepts onto time, converting lived experience into a line of interchangeable, homogeneous points. This distinction exposes the core conceptual divide in Bergson duration versus spatialized time AI: modern artificial intelligence systems spatialise time through discrete training iterations and discrete context token indices, compressing all historical learning into habit-like weight matrices while discarding pure episodic recollection.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Bergson grounded his causal analysis on clinical observations of aphasia and psychic trauma:

1. Dissociation of Habit and Recollection: Pathology demonstrates that patients who have lost the motor habit of speech can retain the memory of past ideas, while patients who can articulate words fluently may lose all episodic recognition of when or where they acquired them.

2. Spatialisation as Mnemonic Distortion: Treating time as a succession of identical clock ticks or discrete integer counters treats the learner at step t+1 as identical to the learner at step t, ignoring that the cumulative passage of experience alters the state space itself.

3. Relevance to Machine Learning: In neural network architectures, frozen connection weights function purely as habit-memory (compressed residue of historical loss gradients). Without external episodic storage or dynamic retrieval (the computational analogue of pure memory), machine learning models inevitably suffer catastrophic forgetting when exposed to non-stationary environments.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

The qualitative distinction between procedural habit and episodic recollection has persisted for over a century, providing the explicit structural precursor to Endel Tulving's canonical 1972 division between semantic memory and episodic memory in neuropsychology.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

Classified as robust (<20%). While Bergson's 1922 debate with Albert Einstein regarding the physics of relativity ended with physicists rejecting Bergson's critique of relativistic simultaneity, his phenomenological model of internal time consciousness and memory consolidation remains robust and empirically validated in modern cognitive psychology.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Bergson's critique of spatialized time does not mean that discrete mathematics, clock-driven hardware accelerators, or digital optimization loops are invalid; rather, it delineates that a discrete counter of training steps cannot capture the qualitative state transitions of a learning organism.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

AI system designers and organizational theorists should recognize that standardizing on procedural documentation or parametric weights provides only habit-memory; sustaining true institutional and systemic memory requires dedicated, addressable episodic archives that preserve dated decision contexts.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Bergson, H. (1896). Matière et mémoire: essai sur la relation du corps à l'esprit. Paris: Félix Alcan. English translation: Matter and Memory, trans. N. M. Paul and W. S. Palmer (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1911). https://doi.org/10.1037/10006-000